Today we turn to our third big question. This question can be introduced by an example.

Suppose that in the year 2069 the surviving members of this Introduction to Philosophy class decided to have an Intro to Philosophy reunion, and all gathered in this room. Suppose that they decided to get a group picture taken.

Now imagine that, via some sort of time travel device, I now have that photo, and show it to you. You might ask: Am I one of those people? Which one am I?

It is very natural to assume that these questions must have determinate answers. There must be some fact of the matter about whether one of the people in the photo is you. And, if one is you, there must be some fact of the matter about which one is you.

Let's suppose that this is true: there must be a fact about whether you survive to be in this picture, and must be a fact about which of the survivors you are.

Then we can ask a question about these facts:

The survival question: What does it take for for some person at some other time to be you?

To introduce our main answers to the survival question, it will be useful to think about a simple, uncontroversial example of survival.

All of you believe that you will wake up tomorrow in your bed. To put the same point another way, all of you believe that the person now sitting in your seat is the same person as — identical to — the person who will wake up in your bed tomorrow morning.

What do we mean when we say that you are identical to that person?

Here it is important to get clear at the outset on one distinction which, if not attended to, can make these questions more confusing than they have to be. This is the distinction between **numerical** and **qualitative** identity.

Here are some examples to help you see the distinction.

Suppose that I have a pair of golf balls that are just the same in every respect — they have the same things printed on them, and they are the same shape and color. They are therefore qualitatively resembling. But are they numerically identical? No. They are two, not one.

Now consider a different golf ball. Suppose that tomorrow you paint the golf ball green. Now think about the golf ball today, and the golf ball tomorrow. Does the golf ball today have the same superficial properties that it has tomorrow? No — one is white, and the other is green. So they are not qualitatively resembling. But are they numerically identical? It seems like they are — it is one and the same golf ball that was white today, and is green tomorrow.

In ordinary language, we sometimes use ‘identical’ to when we really mean ‘qualitatively resembling.’ But it is important to keep these two notions apart.

To say that x at t1 and y at t2 are numerically identical is to say that they are literally the same thing — they are one, not two.

To say that x at t1 and y at t2 qualitatively resemble each other is to say that they have just the same superficial properties.

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